去朋友家做客

一个巴西学生和一顿中国晚饭

Dinner at a Friend's Home

A Brazilian student and a Chinese family dinner

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 卢卡斯[†]是从巴西[‡]来的留学生，在北京的一所大学学习中文。有一天下课以后，同学张浩[§]对他说：“这个星期六晚上，来我家吃饭吧！我妈做菜做得特别好。”卢卡斯非常高兴。来中国半年了，这还是他第一次去中国人家里做客。

带什么礼物？

2 那天晚上，卢卡斯在网上看了很多文章，讲的都是怎么在中国做客。他一边看一边写，写了满满一张纸：要带礼物，进门要换鞋，主人给你东西，要先客气[¶]几次……第二天，他问张浩：“我应该带什么礼物？”“不用带，人来就行了。”张浩说。卢卡斯想：网上说，中国人常常说“不用”，可是那只是客气。难道我真的什么都不带吗？“还有，我应该怎么叫你的爸爸妈妈？”“叫叔叔[*]、阿姨[#]就行。”

† 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas
‡ 巴西 *Bāxī* Brazil
§ 张浩 *Zhāng Hào* Zhang Hao
¶ 客气 *kèqi* to be polite (by declining)
* 叔叔 *shūshu* uncle (polite address)
\# 阿姨 *āyí* auntie (polite address)

Lucas was an international student from Brazil, studying Chinese at a university in Beijing. One day after class his classmate Zhang Hao said to him, "Come over to my place for dinner this Saturday evening! My mum is a fantastic cook." Lucas was delighted. He had been in China for half a year, and this was the first time he had been invited to a Chinese family's home. 1

What Gift to Bring?

That evening Lucas read lots of articles online, all about how to be a guest in China. He took notes as he read and filled a whole sheet of paper: bring a gift; change your shoes when you go in; when the host offers you something, politely say no a few times first... The next day he asked Zhang Hao, "What gift should I bring?" "You don't need to bring anything. Just come," said Zhang Hao. Lucas thought: the internet says Chinese people often say "no need", but they're only being polite. Am I really supposed to bring nothing at all? "And what should I call your parents?" "Just call them Uncle and Auntie." 2

3 星期六下午，卢卡斯[1]去商店买礼物。他一方面想送一点儿特别的东西，另一方面又怕送错。网上说，不能送钟，因为“送钟”听起来跟“送终”[2]一样。也最好不送梨[3]，因为“梨”和离开的“离”声音一样。最后，他买了一些很好的水果，又带上了一包从巴西[4]带来的咖啡。

4 晚上七点，卢卡斯到了张浩[5]家。一开门，他就看见门口放着一排鞋。他马上换了鞋，张浩的妈妈笑着给了他一双拖鞋[6]。卢卡斯拿出礼物：“阿姨[7]，这是给您的。”“哎呀[8]，来就来，还带什么东西！”张妈妈把礼物推了回来。卢卡斯早就知道会这样，又把礼物送了过去。两个人推了三次，张妈妈才收下。

5 可是张妈妈没有打开，只是把东西放在了旁边。

1 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas
2 送终 *sòngzhōng* to attend a dying relative
3 梨 *lí* pear
4 巴西 *Bāxī* Brazil
5 张浩 *Zhāng Hào* Zhang Hao
6 拖鞋 *tuōxié* slippers
7 阿姨 *āyí* auntie (polite address)
8 哎呀 *āiyā* oh my

On Saturday afternoon Lucas went to the shops to buy a gift. On the one hand he wanted to give something special; on the other hand he was afraid of giving the wrong thing. The internet said you mustn't give a clock, because "giving a clock" (song zhong) sounds just like "attending someone's last moments". And it was best not to give pears, because "pear" (li) sounds the same as the "li" of "leave". In the end he bought some very good fruit, and he also took along a bag of coffee he had brought from Brazil. 3

At seven in the evening Lucas arrived at Zhang Hao's home. As soon as the door opened, he saw a row of shoes by the entrance. He changed his shoes at once, and Zhang Hao's mother handed him a pair of slippers with a smile. Lucas took out his gifts. "Auntie, these are for you." "Oh my, it's enough that you came. Why bring anything?" Mrs Zhang pushed the gifts back. Lucas had known this would happen, so he held them out again. They pushed them back and forth three times before Mrs Zhang finally accepted. 4

But Mrs Zhang didn't open them; she just put them to one side. 5

5 卢卡斯[†]有点儿紧张：在巴西[‡]，收到礼物要马上打开，还要说“太漂亮了”。难道她不喜欢吗？张浩[§]好像看出了他的想法，小声说：“没事儿，我们这儿都是这样的。客人走了以后再打开。”

吃不完的菜

6 桌子上已经放满了菜：有鱼，有肉，有饺子，还有一大碗鸡汤。“这么多菜！我们只有四个人啊！”卢卡斯说。张浩的爸爸笑着说：“不多，不多。坐，快坐！”大家刚坐下，张妈妈就拿起筷子，给卢卡斯夹[¶]了一大块鱼。“谢谢阿姨[*]，我自己来，不用了……”卢卡斯记得网上说的，要先客气[#]一下。“别客气，多吃点儿！反正菜多得很！”张妈妈又给他夹了两个饺子。

7 菜做得真好吃，卢卡斯吃得很开心。

† 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas
‡ 巴西 *Bāxī* Brazil
§ 张浩 *Zhāng Hào* Zhang Hao
¶ 夹 *jiā* to pick up (with chopsticks)
* 阿姨 *āyí* auntie (polite address)
客气 *kèqi* to be polite (by declining)

Lucas felt a little uneasy. In Brazil, when you get a present you open it right away and say how lovely it is. Could it be she didn't like it? Zhang Hao seemed to read his mind and said quietly, "It's fine, that's how everyone does it here. You open presents after the guest leaves." 5

The Never-Ending Dishes

The table was already covered with dishes: fish, meat, dumplings, and a big bowl of chicken soup. "So many dishes! There are only four of us!" said Lucas. Zhang Hao's father laughed. "It's not much, not much at all. Sit down, sit down!" No sooner had everyone sat down than Mrs Zhang picked up her chopsticks and put a big piece of fish into Lucas's bowl. "Thank you, Auntie, I can help myself, really, there's no need..." Lucas remembered what he'd read online: be polite and decline first. "Don't be shy, eat up! There's plenty of food anyway!" Mrs Zhang put two dumplings in his bowl as well. 6

The food was truly delicious, and Lucas ate happily. 7

在巴西[†]，他妈妈常常说：碗里的饭吃得干干净净，做饭的人才会高兴。所以，碗里有什么，他就吃什么，一点儿也不留。可是他的碗一空，张妈妈就马上给他夹[‡]新的菜。他吃完了鱼，又来了肉；吃完了肉，又来了饺子。

过了一会儿，张爸爸站起来，从厨房[§]里又拿出来一个菜：“这是我做的，你尝尝[¶]。”卢卡斯[*]已经吃得很饱了。他一方面真的吃不下了，另一方面又怕不吃完，主人会不高兴。难道中国人每顿饭都吃这么多吗？他只好又吃了一碗。最后，他吃得站都站不起来了。张浩[#]终于看出来了，笑着说：“妈，别夹了，他真的吃不下了！”

† 巴西 *Bāxī* Brazil
‡ 夹 *jiā* to pick up (with chopsticks)
§ 厨房 *chúfáng* kitchen
¶ 尝尝 *chángchang* to have a taste
* 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas
张浩 *Zhāng Hào* Zhang Hao

In Brazil his mother always said that only when your plate is licked clean will 7
the cook be happy. So whatever was in his bowl, he ate it, and didn't leave a scrap. But every time his bowl was empty, Mrs Zhang immediately filled it with more food. When he finished the fish, the meat arrived; when he finished the meat, the dumplings arrived.

After a while Mr Zhang stood up and brought yet another dish out of the 8
kitchen. "I made this one. Have a taste." Lucas was already very full. On the one hand he really couldn't eat any more; on the other hand he was afraid the hosts would be upset if he didn't finish. Did Chinese people really eat this much at every meal? He had no choice but to eat another bowlful. In the end he had eaten so much that he could hardly stand up. Zhang Hao finally noticed, and said with a laugh, "Mum, stop giving him food. He really can't eat any more!"

我来!

9 吃完饭，卢卡斯[†]马上站起来，拿起大家的碗：“我来洗！”“那怎么行！你是客人，坐着！”张妈妈把碗拿了过去。“我来！”“我来！”两个人一个拿着碗，一个不放手。张爸爸在旁边笑得不行：“卢卡斯，你别跟她争了，反正你也赢不了。我跟她争了二十年，一次也没赢过！”

10 九点多，卢卡斯要回学校了。他在门口说：“叔叔[‡]阿姨[§]再见，你们别送了。”可是张浩[¶]一家都换了鞋，跟他一起下了楼。到了楼下，他说：“请回吧！”张爸爸说：“没关系，反正我们吃完饭也要出来走走。”就这样，他们一直把卢卡斯送到了地铁站。

11 在路上，卢卡斯问张浩：“你妈妈为什么一直给我夹[*]菜？我每一碗都吃完了啊！”

† 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas
‡ 叔叔 *shūshu* uncle (polite address)
§ 阿姨 *āyí* auntie (polite address)
¶ 张浩 *Zhāng Hào* Zhang Hao
* 夹 *jiā* to pick up (with chopsticks)

Let Me!

When the meal was over, Lucas jumped up and gathered everyone's bowls. 9
"I'll wash up!" "Certainly not! You're our guest. Sit down!" Mrs Zhang took the bowls from him. "Let me!" "No, let me!" One of them held the bowls and the other wouldn't let go. Mr Zhang was laughing his head off beside them. "Lucas, don't argue with her. You'll never win anyway. I've been arguing with her for twenty years and haven't won once!"

A little after nine, it was time for Lucas to go back to the university. At 10
the door he said, "Goodbye, Uncle, Auntie. Please don't see me out." But the whole family changed their shoes and went downstairs with him. At the bottom of the stairs he said, "Please, go back in!" Mr Zhang said, "It's no trouble. We always go for a walk after dinner anyway." And so they walked Lucas all the way to the subway station.

On the way, Lucas asked Zhang Hao, "Why did your mum keep giving me 11
food? I finished every bowl!"

11 张浩[†]笑了：“就是因为你都吃完了。在中国，碗里空了，主人会以为你还没吃饱。你留一点儿，她才知道你饱了。”卢卡斯[‡]站住了：“难道我今天吃那么多，都是因为我太听我妈妈的话了吗？”两个人都笑了。张浩又说：“其实，我妈一方面是怕你吃不饱，另一方面也是想告诉你：我们很欢迎你。”

到我家来

12 两个星期以后，卢卡斯请张浩一家来他租的小房子吃饭。“这次我请你们吃巴西[§]烤肉[¶]。”他说，“也请你们试试我们巴西人的习惯。”他告诉他们：在巴西，朋友见面要拥抱[*]；朋友家请吃饭，晚一点儿到也没关系；吃饭的时候，大家自己拿，想吃多少就拿多少。

† 张浩 *Zhāng Hào* Zhang Hao
‡ 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas
§ 巴西 *Bāxī* Brazil
¶ 烤肉 *kǎoròu* barbecue
* 拥抱 *yōngbào* to hug

Zhang Hao laughed. "It's precisely because you finished. In China, if your bowl is empty, the host thinks you're still hungry. Only if you leave a little will she know you're full." Lucas stopped in his tracks. "You mean I ate all that today just because I listened to my mother too well?" They both burst out laughing. Zhang Hao went on, "Actually, on the one hand my mum was afraid you wouldn't get enough to eat, and on the other hand she wanted to tell you that you're very welcome with us." 11

Come to My Place

Two weeks later, Lucas invited the Zhang family to dinner at the little flat he rented. "This time I'm treating you to Brazilian barbecue," he said. "And I'd like you to try out our Brazilian customs, too." He told them that in Brazil friends hug when they meet; if friends invite you to dinner, it's fine to arrive a little late; and at the meal, everyone helps themselves and takes as much as they like. 12

13 说好七点，张家六点五十就到了。卢卡斯[†]的肉还没烤[‡]好呢！张妈妈手里拿着一大包水果，还有一大碗自己包的饺子。这次，卢卡斯先说了："哎呀[§]，来就来，还带什么东西！"大家都笑了。张爸爸还跟他拥抱[¶]了一下，样子很不习惯。

14 吃饭的时候，张妈妈还是不停地往卢卡斯的碗里放肉。"阿姨[*]，今天在我家，大家自己拿！""习惯了，改不了！"张妈妈笑着说。这一次，卢卡斯有办法了：他在碗里留了一块肉，张妈妈果然就不给他夹[#]了。

15 吃完饭，张爸爸站起来说："我下楼去买点儿喝的。"卢卡斯一下跳了起来，比他跑得还快："我来！反正今天我是主人！"很晚了，张家要走了。张妈妈在门口说："别送了，快回去吧！"卢卡斯已经换好了鞋："那怎么行？难道主人可以不送客人吗？"他一直把他们送到了地铁站。

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† 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas
‡ 烤 *kǎo* to grill
§ 哎呀 *āiyā* oh my
¶ 拥抱 *yōngbào* to hug
* 阿姨 *āyí* auntie (polite address)
\# 夹 *jiā* to pick up (with chopsticks)

They had agreed on seven o'clock, but the Zhangs arrived at ten to seven. 13
Lucas's meat wasn't even grilled yet! Mrs Zhang was carrying a big bag of fruit and a large bowl of dumplings she had made herself. This time Lucas got in first. "Oh my, it's enough that you came. Why bring anything?" Everyone laughed. Mr Zhang even gave him a hug, though he did it very awkwardly.

At dinner, Mrs Zhang still kept putting meat into Lucas's bowl. "Auntie, 14
today we're at my place. Everyone helps themselves!" "Old habits, I can't change them!" Mrs Zhang said, laughing. This time Lucas knew what to do: he left one piece of meat in his bowl, and sure enough, Mrs Zhang stopped giving him more.

After dinner, Mr Zhang stood up and said, "I'll pop downstairs and buy 15
something to drink." Lucas leapt to his feet and got to the door faster than him. "Let me! I'm the host today, after all!" It got late, and the Zhangs had to leave. At the door Mrs Zhang said, "Don't see us out. Go back inside!" Lucas had already put his shoes on. "Certainly not! How could a host not see his guests out?" He walked them all the way to the subway station.

15 张浩[†]看着他，笑着说：“卢卡斯[‡]，你现在简直比中国人还像中国人了！”

† 张浩 *Zhāng Hào* Zhang Hao

‡ 卢卡斯 *Lúkǎsī* Lucas

Zhang Hao looked at him and laughed. "Lucas, you're more Chinese than the Chinese now!" 15